

Presentation skills

- We all need to present our ideas effectively in person.
- Oral presentations vary in style, range, complexity, and formality.
- They may include convention speeches, reports at national meetings, reports via teleconferencing networks, technical briefings for colleagues, and speeches to community groups.
- These talks may be designed to inform (to describe new government safety requirements), to persuade (to induce company officers to vote a pay raise), or to do both.
- The higher your status, on the job or in the community, the more you can expect to give oral presentations.

Presentation skills

- Presentation skills are crucial in today's professional landscape, enhancing one's ability to communicate effectively and persuasively.
- They not only help in delivering messages clearly but also **boost confidence and engagement with the audience.**
- Mastering presentation skills can lead to career advancements, improved professional relationships, and increased influence.
- We all need to present our ideas **effectively in person.**
- Oral presentations vary in **style, range, complexity, and formality.**

Advantage of Presentation Skills

- Unlike written documents, oral presentations are truly interactive. In face-to-face communication, you can rely on **body language, vocal tone, eye contact, and other elements of human chemistry**—a likable personality can have a powerful effect on audience receptiveness.
- Oral presentations provide for **give-and-take**, which does not happen with traditional written documents. As you see how your audience reacts, you can **adjust your presentation** accordingly and answer questions immediately.

Benefits of improving presentation skills

- Enhanced communication: clearer and more impactful message delivery.
- Increased confidence: greater self-assurance during public speaking.
- Career advancement: better job prospects and professional growth.
- Stronger engagement: improved ability to captivate and maintain audience interest.
- Influence and persuasion: more effective in convincing and motivating others

Drawbacks of oral Presentation

- In a written document, you generally have plenty of time to think about what you're saying and how you're saying it, and to revise until the message is just right.
- For an oral presentation, one attempt is basically all you get, and all this pressure makes it easier to stumble. **(People consistently rank fear of public speaking higher than fear of dying!).**

Drawbacks of oral Presentation

- Also, an oral report is limited in the amount and complexity of information it can present. Readers of a written report can follow their own pace and direction, going back and forth, perhaps skimming some sections and studying others.
- In an oral presentation, you establish the pace and the information flow, thereby creating the risk of “losing” or boring the listeners.

What is important in a presentation?

- As mentioned earlier, you should try to implement a combination of the tips to give a successful presentation.
- It should be noted that not every one of these tips needs to fit in your own presentation.
- In addition, too many of these tips can make the presentation look overloaded and too "rehearsed".
- Therefore, think carefully in advance about what you want to pay particular attention to.

PLANNING YOUR PRESENTATION

- Analyze Your Listeners
- Work from an Explicit Purpose Statement
- Analyze Your Speaking Situation
- Select an Appropriate Delivery Method

Analyze Your Listeners

- Assess your listeners' needs, knowledge, concerns, level of involvement, and possible objections.
- Many audiences include people with varied technical backgrounds.
- Unless you have a good idea of each person's background, speak to a general, heterogeneous audience, as in a classroom of mixed majors.

Work from an Explicit Purpose Statement

- Formulate, on paper, a statement of purpose in two or three sentences.
- Why, exactly, are you speaking on this subject?
- Who are your listeners?
- What do you want the listeners to think, know, or do? (A solid purpose statement can also serve as the introduction to your presentation.)

Analyze Your Speaking Situation

The more you can discover about the circumstances, the setting, and the constraints for your presentation, the more deliberately you will be able to prepare.

Select an Appropriate Delivery Method

- Your presentation's effectiveness will depend largely on how it connects with listeners. Different types of delivery create different connections.
- Memorized Delivery
- Impromptu Delivery
- Scripted Delivery
- Extemporaneous Delivery

Memorized Delivery

- A memorized delivery seldom connects with listeners because the speaker is too busy reciting the lines and trying to remember everything.
- This type of delivery takes a long time to prepare, offers no chance for revision during the presentation, and spells disaster if you lose your place.
- Avoid this type of delivery in most workplace settings.

Impromptu Delivery

- An impromptu (offthe-cuff) delivery can be a natural way of connecting with listeners----but only when you really know your material, feel comfortable with your audience, and are n an informal speaking situation (group brainstorming, or a response to a question: “Tell us about your team’s progress on the automation project”).
- Avoid impromptu deliveries for complex information---no matter how well you know the material.

Scripted Delivery

- For a complex technical presentation, a conference paper, or a formal speech, you may want to read your material verbatim from a prepared script.
- Scripted presentations work well if you have many details to present, are talkative, or have a strict time limit (e.g., at a conference), or if this audience makes you nervous.
- Consider a scripted delivery when you want the content, organization, and style of your presentation to be as near perfect as possible.

Extemporaneous Delivery

- An extemporaneous delivery is carefully planned, practiced, and based on notes that keep you on track.
- In this natural way of addressing an audience, you glance at your material and speak in a conversational style.
- Extemporaneous delivery is based on key ideas in sentence or topic outline form, often projected as overhead transparencies or as slides generated from presentation software such as Microsoft PowerPoint.

Planning your Presentation

- Research Your Topic
- Aim for Simplicity and Conciseness
- Anticipate Audience Questions
- Outline Your Presentation
- Plan Your Visuals
- Prepare Your Visuals
- Consider the Available Technology

Research Your Topic

- Do your homework.
- Be prepared to support each assertion, opinion, conclusion, and recommendation with evidence and reason.
- Check your facts for accuracy.
- your audience expects to hear a knowledgeable speaker.
- Don't disappoint them.
- Begin gathering material well ahead of time. Use summarizing techniques to identify and organize major points.
- If your preparation is simply a spoken version of a written report, you need far less preparation.

Aim for Simplicity and Conciseness

- Keep your presentation short and simple.
- Boil the material down to a few main points.
- Listeners' normal attention span is about twenty minutes. After that, they begin tuning out.
- Time yourself in practice sessions and trim as needed.

Anticipate Audience Questions

- Consider those parts of your presentation that listeners might question or challenge.
- You might need to clarify or justify information that is new, controversial, disappointing, or surprising.

Plan Your Visuals

- Think of each visual as an image that flashes before your listeners. They will not have the luxury of studying the visual at leisure.
- Listeners need to know at a glance what they are looking at and what it means.
- In addition to being able to read the visual, listeners need to understand it.
- When your material is extremely detailed or complex, distribute handouts to each listener.

Prepare Your Visuals

Instead of just presenting overhead versions of printed pages, explore the full visual possibilities of your media.

Consider the Available Technology

- Today's audiences expect communication that displays high visual quality. **Using digital and video cameras, Web sites, and presentation software**, you can create dynamic presentations that appeal to the listener's multiple senses.
- Using an automatic, remote-controlled transparency feeder and a pencil-sized laser pointer, you can deliver a smooth and elegant presentation.
- Despite the possibilities inherent in the technology, you are still responsible for a presentation **that is well researched and professionally delivered.**

Deviling your Presentation

- Cultivate the Human Landscape
- Keep Your Listeners Oriented
- Manage Your Visuals
- Manage Your Presentation Style
- Manage Your Speaking Situation

Cultivate the Human Landscape

- Try to meet some audience members before your presentation. We all feel more comfortable with people we know. Don't be afraid to smile.
- Overcome your shyness. Research indicates that shy people are seen as less credible, trustworthy, likable, attractive, and knowledgeable.
- Don't make your point at someone else's expense. If your topic is controversial, decide how to speak candidly and persuasively with the least chance of offending anyone.

Keep Your Listeners Oriented

- Help your listeners to focus their attention and organize their understanding. Give them a map, some guidance, and highlights.
- Say something to establish immediate common ground. Show how your presentation has meaning for them, personally.
- Good examples are informative and persuasive.
- Last things are best remembered. Help listeners remember the main points.

Manage Your Visuals

- If you plan to draw on a chalkboard or poster, do the drawings beforehand (in multicolors). Otherwise, listeners will be sitting idly while you draw away.
- Make sure you organize your media materials and the physical layout beforehand, to avoid fumbling during the presentation. Check your visual sequence against your storyboard.

Manage Your Speaking Situation

- Be responsive to listener feedback.
- Stick to your plan.
- Level listeners with something to remember.
- Allow time for questions and answers.

Manage Your Presentation Style

- In order to give each of your listeners the feeling of being important and to make them feel personally addressed, it is particularly important to maintain eye contact with the audience during the presentation.
- Not only does this exude confidence, but it also helps your audience to connect with you and your subject.
- It also helps you feel less nervous.

Maintain eye contact

- Find someone in the audience who seems to be genuinely interested in the topic and is listening attentively (for example, your lecturer).
- Make eye contact with this person at the beginning of the presentation.
- Once you start feeling more calm and confident let your gaze drift over the audience to address the other listeners as well.
- Keep returning your gaze to the initial person to stay calm throughout the whole presentation

Maintain eye contact

- Another alternative is to find a fixed point in the room (preferably on the wall behind the audience) which you fix at the beginning of the presentation.
- Similar to the first example, after you have achieved confidence, you can let your gaze wander over the audience and return to the previously selected fixed point again and again.

Be careful while using eye contact

- **Don't** look at the screen!
- **Don't** look at the floor!
- **Don't** just look at your index cards!
- **Don't** just look at the laptop!

Use of gestures and facial expressions

- To emphasize the content of your presentation, it is advisable to use appropriate gestures and body language to get your message across.
- Avoid crossed arms, hands behind your back, or in your pockets during a presentation.
- Always stand up straight, and try not to appear tense or stressed.
- You can do that by using your hands and arms to emphasize what you are saying and get your message across.
- Your facial expressions should always be friendly and open.
- Smile and show that you enjoy the topic and you are confident in the information you are presenting.

Avoid distractions

- Often you will not be able to avoid the use of aids. For example, you may need to use a laser pointer to show something on the screen, or you may need to use a pen to write something down on a flipchart.
- To avoid distractions for you and the audience, get into the habit of putting down tools you don't need!
- That way you will not be tempted to deal with them in the first place.
- You will also have your hands free for gestures.

Practice makes perfect

- Practice makes perfect, right? If you prepare well before the presentation, you will feel more relaxed and confident while presenting and it will also improve your body language.
- **Here are some ways to help you prepare for a presentation:**
- Rehearse in front of a crowd
- Take notes
- Experiment
- Time yourself
- Record yourself

Be confident

- By appearing self-confident, you convey to the listener that you are confident in your topic and have prepared yourself sufficiently.
- Try to relax and not appear too stressed or nervous.
- Another tip for advanced speakers: Step out in front of the podium and walk around the room and get closer to the audience.
- This also exudes self-confidence and helps in attracting your audience's attention.

Effective beginning/end

- Good presentation skills can help you in captivating your audience straight away.
- In order to do that, you should start your presentation with a bang.
- Many studies show that if you can capture someone's interest straight away, there's a good chance they'll listen to the rest of the presentation.
- Shock the audience, ask them to imagine something or think of a what-if situation, share a personal story, share a joke, use a quote, or a video.
- You should also give an overview of the time and structure of your presentation.

Effective beginning/end

- This outline should run through your presentation so that you can always assign the individual contents to an outline point.
- It is also helpful for your audience to have the outline displayed in a slimmed-down form during the whole presentation.
- How you end the presentation is as important as how you start it.
- A weak ending will leave the audience uninspired.
- But a good ending will motivate them and help them walk away on a positive note. For example, include a call to action, end the presentation with a memorable quote, or a personal story, and don't forget to thank and acknowledge the audience.

Speak freely

- The headline speaks for itself. To make the presentation as lively and enjoyable as possible, you should avoid reading it off.
- Speak freely, slowly, and clearly. If you are not yet confident in what you are presenting, try using note cards.
- But keep in mind: No continuous text, but only short, concise bullet points!
- If you use note cards to support you, it is especially advisable at this point to memorize at least the beginning and end of your presentation, as eye contact is crucial at these points.

Avoid filler words

- In order to make your presentation flow as smoothly and confidently as possible, you should avoid using filler words such as "um," "so," and so on.
- For your listeners, these words convey insecurity and inadequate preparation

Bring along something to share

- In addition to a handout, other small takeaways can also significantly improve your presentation.
- For example, if you are giving a presentation on gummy bears, why not offer some to your audience?
- If you are giving a presentation about your fishing hobby, why not show the audience your fishing equipment?

Use different types of media

- A presentation can quickly become boring and monotonous. To avoid this, it is advisable to use different types of media.
- For example, combine videos and flipcharts, use the whiteboard, or show something practical on a model.
- This will increase the attention of your audience enormously and will help in keeping them engaged until the end.

Use effective pauses

- When giving a presentation, you should keep in mind that you have already heard the content several times - your audience probably hasn't! Therefore, give your audience enough time to read and understand the content of your slides.
- Effective use of speech pauses is a master technique. It is one of the most versatile tools in a presenter's toolbox. Yet very few people perform it well. A pause, if used correctly, can add a great deal to your presentation or speech. Pause before, during, or after saying something that you would like to emphasize. Pausing between two different parts of your presentation can indicate to the audience that something new is coming. A quick pause could also help you in remembering your next point, without the audience noticing that you forgot what to say.

Speak the language of the audience

- When creating your presentation, you should already think about your target audience.
- This will help you present successfully later on. It is especially important that you speak the language of the audience.
- Use appropriate and relevant examples.
- Use "strong" and meaningful words in short sentences to avoid losing the audience.
- Make sure to use appropriate analogies and anecdotes and avoid foreign words, empty phrases, and clichés.
- If you have to use foreign words, explain them in a handout or footnote within the presentation

Engage with the audience

- Always try to keep the attention of your audience and keep them engaged during a presentation.
- To do this, it is advisable to regularly involve the audience. One way to do this is to ask questions.
- Deliberately ask "easy" questions so that can easily be answered by your audience.
Another way to involve the audience in your presentation is by interacting with them.
- To make a point clearer, you can use an example to explain it in more detail, using a person (whose name you should know).
- You can address participants directly and refer to their work.

Don't fight the stage fright

- Stage fright is one of the biggest enemies of a presentation, yet you shouldn't let yourself be a victim of your fear.
- Do not fight it, rather address your fear and try and accept it, and transform it into positive enthusiasm.
- Don't let your stage fright get you all worked up and nervous.
- Take a couple of deep breaths to get oxygen to your brain and relax your body.

Right angle on standing

One of the most frequent questions that speakers ask themselves during a presentation is, how do I best position myself, and where do I stand in front of the audience?

You have a free stage without a podium

- In many cases, you will be facing your audience in a "free space", without a podium.
- This gives you a lot of room to move, but at the same time, it creates uncertainty because you don't know how to position yourself properly or how to move.
- Avoid standing frontally in front of the audience! This frontal facing is unconsciously perceived negatively by the audience.
- It is perceived by the audience as a kind of frontal attack and causes stress in your audience.
- Make sure to stand slightly to the side of the audience. If you notice during the presentation that you are again standing frontally in front of your audience, simply move your right or left foot 20 cm forward

You have a podium at your disposal

- A podium makes it easier to decide how to position yourself and where to stand in front of the audience.
- In order not to make your presentation too monotonous, it is advisable to leave the "safe position" behind the lectern from time to time, e.g. to walk to the other side of the screen or to show something on the flipchart.
- This brings movement into your presentation and helps keep the connection with your audience.

Create something with the whiteboard

- PowerPoint is no longer the tool of choice for a successful presentation.
- Photo collages, company logos on every slide and flashing text boxes often distract from the essentials.
- A presentation convinces the audience especially when they witness how something is being created.

Create something with the whiteboard

- In addition to the classic flipchart, the whiteboard is recommended for this purpose.
- This is because diagrams, keywords and the results of a brainstorming session are written in real time on a whiteboard.
- Board markers allow a wide range of colors and the magnetic property of pinning additional information.
- The result of the presentation produced in this way is remembered longer than ready-made slides

Key point

“Disrespect can permanently shut doors that apologies cannot reopen. Consider this carefully”

From Stop Letting Everything Affect You by Daniel chidiac